

PLAN (MICHAEL) B(AY)

Financial psychologist Dr. Brad Klontz (remember him?) told me that in order to have \$50,000 a year to spend during my retirement (the equivalent of a pretty average annual salary), I would need to accrue \$1.5 million in the next twenty to thirty years.

Upon hearing this figure, I sputtered. The only way this could happen, I told him, was if somehow I was able to do one big action movie in my career and then never touch that money again. (On my podcast, I called it “Plan Bay” after the blockbuster filmmaker Michael Bay.) Plan A, though, would just have to be saving the old-fashioned way.

Where does the money for my current retirement account come from? I get paid infrequently in lump sums and don’t have a consistent salary, so when I do get paid, I have to break it up to make it last. As I mentioned in previous chapters, I’ve sold some TV shows that never aired. One of those shows netted me \$50,000: I put \$19,000 in a savings account, used \$14,000 to pay off old debts (credit card, medical, two of my three student loans), and eventually put \$16,000 into something called a SEP IRA retirement account. Wow, go me! Some experts would admonish me for starting so late. Frankly, I don’t like their condescending tones.

But before we go deeper into the world of retirement savings, let’s take a second to remember the incredibly important fact that not everyone *can* save for retirement. Some people who work don’t have anything left in their paychecks to save. Some people in marginalized communities don’t often think about the future—not just because they can’t imagine having enough money to stop working or because the data shows their life spans are shorter but also because the future is just not marketed to people like them.

“When you see advertisements for retirement, and planning for your future, it’s typically a straight, white couple walking down the beach holding hands